Meanwhile the prince took De Guiche aside and asked him how the prisoner had been taken and who this young man was.

'Monsieur,' said the prince, turning toward Raoul, 'I know that you have a letter from my sister, Madame de Longueville; but I see that you have preferred commending yourself to me by giving me good counsel.'

'My lord,' said Raoul, colouring up, 'I did not wish to interrupt your highness in a conversation so important as that in which you were engaged with the count. But here is the letter.'

'Very well,' said the prince; 'give it to me later. Here is the prisoner; let us attend to what is most pressing.'

The prisoner was one of those military adventurers who sold their blood to whoever would buy, and grew old in stratagems and spoils. Since he had been taken he had not uttered a word, so that it was not known to what country he belonged. The prince looked at him with unspeakable distrust.

'Of what country are you?' asked the prince.

The prisoner muttered a few words in a foreign tongue.

'Ah! ah! it seems that he is a Spaniard. Do you speak Spanish, Grammont?'

'Faith, my lord, but indifferently.'

'And I not at all,' said the prince, laughing. 'Gentlemen,' he said, turning to those who were near him 'can any one of you speak Spanish and serve me as interpreter?'

'I can, my lord,' said Raoul.

'Ah, you speak Spanish?'

'Enough, I think, to fulfil your highness's wishes on this occasion.'

Meanwhile the prisoner had remained impassive and as if he had no understanding of what was taking place.

'My lord asks of what country you are,' said the young man, in the purest Castilian.

'*Ich bin ein Deutscher*,' replied the prisoner.

'What in the devil does he say?' asked the prince. 'What new gibberish is that?'

'He says he is German, my lord,' replied Raoul; 'but I doubt it, for his accent is bad and his pronunciation defective.'

'Then you speak German, also?' asked the prince.

'Yes, my lord.'

'Well enough to question him in that language?'

'Yes, my lord.'

'Question him, then.'

Raoul began the examination, but the result justified his opinion. The prisoner did not understand, or seemed not to understand, what Raoul said to him; and Raoul could hardly understand his replies, containing a mixture of Flemish and Alsatian. However, amidst all the prisoner's efforts to elude a systematic examination, Raoul had recognised his natural accent.

'*Non siete Spagnuolo*,' he said; '*non siete Tedesco; siete Italiano*.'

The prisoner started and bit his lips.

'Ah, that,' said the prince, 'I understand that language thoroughly; and since he is Italian I will myself continue the examination. Thank you, viscount,' continued the prince, laughing, 'and I appoint you from this moment my interpreter.'

But the prisoner was not less unwilling to respond in Italian than in the other languages; his aim was to elude the examination. Therefore, he knew nothing either of the enemy's numbers, or of those in command, or of the purpose of the army.

'Very good,' said the prince, understanding the reason of that ignorance; 'the man was caught in the act of assassination and robbery; he might have purchased his life by speaking; he doesn't wish to speak. Take him out and shoot him.'

The prisoner turned pale. The two soldiers who had brought him in took him, each by one arm, and led him toward the door, whilst the prince, turning to Marshal de Grammont, seemed to have already forgotten the order he had given.

When he reached the threshold of the door the prisoner stopped. The soldiers, who knew only their orders, attempted to force him along.

'One moment,' said the prisoner, in French. 'I am ready to speak, my lord.'

'Ah! ah!' said the prince, laughing, 'I thought we should come to that. I have a sure method of limbering tongues. Young men, take advantage of it against the time when you may be in command.'

'But on condition,' continued the prisoner, 'that your highness will swear that my life shall be safe.'

'Upon my honour,' said the prince.

'Question, then, my lord.'

'Where did the army cross the Lys?'

'Between Saint-Venant and Aire.'

'By whom is it commanded?'

'By Count de Fuonsaldagna, General Beck and the archduke.'

'Of how many does it consist?'

'Eighteen thousand men and thirty-six cannon.'

'And its aim is?'

'Lens.'

'You see; gentlemen!' said the prince, turning with a triumphant air toward Marshal de Grammont and the other officers.

'Yes, my lord,' said the marshal, 'you have divined all that was possible to human genius.'

'Recall Le Plessis, Bellièvre, Villequier and D'Erlac,' said the prince, 'recall all the troops that are on this side of the Lys. Let them hold themselves in readiness to march to-night. To-morrow, according to all probability, we shall attack the enemy.'

'But, my lord,' said Marshal de Grammont, 'consider that when we have collected all our forces we shall have hardly thirteen thousand men.'

'Monsieur le maréchal,' said the prince, with that wonderful glance that was peculiar to him, 'it is with small armies that great battles are won.'

Then turning toward the prisoner, 'Take away that man,' he said, 'and keep him carefully in sight. His life is dependent on the information he has given us; if it is true, he shall be free; if false, let him be shot.'

The prisoner was led away.

'Count de Guiche,' said the prince, 'it is a long time since you saw your father, remain here with him. Monsieur,' he continued, addressing Raoul, 'if you are not too tired, follow me.'

'To the end of the world, my lord!' cried Raoul, feeling an unknown enthusiasm for that young general, who seemed to him so worthy of his renown.

The prince smiled; he despised flatterers, but he appreciated enthusiasts.

formed, possessed of all the qualities essential to the successful soldier—that is to say, the rapid glance, quick decision, fabulous courage. At the same time he was a man of elegant manners and strong mind, so that in addition to the revolution he had made in war, by his new contributions to its methods, he had also made a revolution at Paris, among the young noblemen of the court, whose natural chief he was and who, in distinction from the social leaders of the ancient court, modelled after Bassompierre, Bellegarde and the Duke d'Angoulême, were called the *petits-maîtres*.

At the first words of the Count de Guiche, the prince, having in mind the direction whence came the sound of cannon, had understood everything. The enemy was marching upon Lens, with the intention, doubtless, of securing possession of that town and separating from France the army of France. But in what force was the enemy? Was it a corps sent out to make a diversion? Was it an entire army? To this question De Guiche could not respond.

Now, as these questions involved matters of gravest consequence, it was these to which the prince had especially desired an answer, exact, precise, positive.

Raoul conquered the very natural feeling of timidity he experienced and approaching the prince:

'My lord,' he said, 'will you permit me to hazard a few words on that subject, which will perhaps relieve you of your uncertainty?'

The prince turned and seemed to cover the young man with a single glance; he smiled on perceiving that he was a child hardly fifteen years old.

'Certainly, monsieur, speak,' he said, softening his stern, accented tones, as if he were speaking to a woman.

'My lord,' said Raoul, blushing, 'might examine the Spanish prisoner.'

'Have you a Spanish prisoner?' cried the prince.

'Yes, my lord.'

'Ah, that is true,' said De Guiche; 'I had forgotten it.'

'That is easily understood; it was you who took him, count,' said Raoul, smiling.

The old marshal turned toward the viscount, grateful for that praise of his son, whilst the prince exclaimed:

'The young man is right; let the prisoner be brought in.'

hostile army had disappeared two days before and seemed to have gone out of existence.

Now an enemy is never so near and consequently so threatening, as when he has completely disappeared. The prince was, therefore, contrary to his custom, gloomy and anxious, when an officer entered and announced to Marshal de Grammont that some one wished to see him.

The Duc de Grammont received permission from the prince by a glance and went out. The prince followed him with his eyes and continued looking at the door; no one ventured to speak, for fear of disturbing him.

Suddenly a dull and heavy noise was heard. The prince leaped to his feet, extending his hand in the direction whence came the sound, there was no mistaking it—it was the noise of cannon. Every one stood up.

At that moment the door opened.

'Monseigneur,' said Marshal de Grammont, with a radiant face, 'will your highness permit my son, Count de Guiche, and his travelling companion, Viscount de Bragelonne, to come in and give news of the enemy, whom they have found while we were looking for him?'

'What!' eagerly replied the prince, 'will I permit? I not only permit, I desire; let them come in.'

The marshal introduced the two young men and placed them face to face with the prince.

'Speak, gentlemen,' said the prince, saluting them; 'first speak; we shall have time afterward for the usual compliments. The most urgent thing now is to learn where the enemy is and what he is doing.'

It fell naturally to the Count de Guiche to make reply; not only was he the elder, but he had been presented to the prince by his father. Besides, he had long known the prince, whilst Raoul now saw him for the first time. He therefore narrated to the prince what they had seen from the inn at Mazingarbe.

Meanwhile Raoul closely observed the young general, already made so famous by the battles of Rocroy, Fribourg, and Nordlingen.

Louis de Bourbon, Prince de Condé, who, since the death of his father, Henri de Bourbon, was called, in accordance with the custom of that period, Monsieur le Prince, was a young man, not more than twenty-six or twenty-seven years old, with the eye of an eagle—*agl' occhi grifani*, as Dante says—aquiline nose, long, waving hair, of medium height, well

'Come, monsieur,' he said, 'you are good in council, as we have already discovered; to-morrow we shall know if you are good in action.'

'And I,' said the marshal, 'what am I to do?'

'Wait here to receive the troops. I shall either return for them myself or shall send a courier directing you to bring them to me. Twenty guards, well mounted, are all that I shall need for my escort.'

'That is very few,' said the marshal.

'It is enough,' replied the prince. 'Have you a good horse, Monsieur de Bragelonne?'

'My horse was killed this morning, my lord, and I am mounted provisionally on my lackey's.'

'Choose for yourself in my stables the horse you like best. No false modesty; take the best horse you can find. You will need it this evening, perhaps; you will certainly need it to-morrow.'

Raoul didn't wait to be told twice; he knew that with superiors, especially when those superiors are princes, the highest politeness is to obey without delay or argument; he went down to the stables, picked out a pie-bald Andalusian horse, saddled and bridled it himself, for Athos had advised him to trust no one with those important offices at a time of danger, and went to rejoin the prince, who at that moment mounted his horse.

'Now, monsieur,' he said to Raoul, 'will you give me the letter you have brought?'

Raoul handed the letter to the prince.

'Keep near me,' said the latter.

The prince threw his bridle over the pommel of the saddle, as he was wont to do when he wished to have both hands free, unsealed the letter of Madame de Longueville and started at a gallop on the road to Lens, attended by Raoul and his small escort, whilst messengers sent to recall the troops set out with a loose rein in other directions. The prince read as he hastened on.

'Monsieur,' he said, after a moment, 'they tell me great things of you. I have only to say, after the little that I have seen and heard, that I think even better of you than I have been told.'

Raoul bowed.

Meanwhile, as the little troop drew nearer to Lens, the noise of the cannon sounded louder. The prince kept his gaze fixed in the direction of the sound with the steadfastness of a bird of prey. One would have said that his gaze could pierce the branches of trees which limited his horizon. From time to time his nostrils dilated as if eager for the smell of powder, and he panted like a horse.

At length they heard the cannon so near that it was evident they were within a league of the field of battle, and at a turn of the road they perceived the little village of Aunay.

The peasants were in great commotion. The report of Spanish cruelty had gone out and every one was frightened. The women had already fled, taking refuge in Vitry; only a few men remained. On seeing the prince they hastened to meet him. One of them recognised him.

'Ah, my lord,' he said, 'have you come to drive away those rascal Spaniards and those Lorraine robbers?'

'Yes,' said the prince, 'if you will serve me as guide.'

'Willingly, my lord. Where does your highness wish to go?'

'To some elevated spot whence I can look down on Lens and the surrounding country— '

'In that case, I'm your man.'

'I can trust you—you are a true Frenchman?'

'I am an old soldier of Rocroy, my lord.'

'Here,' said the prince, handing him a purse, 'here is for Rocroy. Now, do you want a horse, or will you go afoot?'

'Afoot, my lord; I have served always in the infantry. Besides, I expect to lead your highness into places where you will have to walk.'

'Come, then,' said the prince; 'let us lose no time.'

The peasant started off, running before the prince's horse; then, a hundred steps from the village, he took a narrow road hidden at the bottom of the valley. For a half league they proceeded thus, the cannon-shot sounding so near that they expected at each discharge to hear the hum of the balls. At length they entered a path which, going out from the road, skirted the mountainside. The prince dismounted, ordered one of his aids and Raoul to follow his example, and directed the others to await his orders, keeping themselves meanwhile on the alert. He then began to ascend the path.

Chapter XXXIV

On the Eve of Battle

RAOUL was aroused from his sombre reflections by his host, who rushed into the apartment crying out, 'The Spaniards! the Spaniards!'

That cry was of such importance as to overcome all preoccupation. The young men made inquiries and ascertained that the enemy was advancing by way of Houdin and Bethune.

While Monsieur d'Arminges gave orders for the horses to be made ready for departure, the two young men ascended to the upper windows of the house and saw in the direction of Marsin and of Lens a large body of infantry and cavalry. This time it was not a wandering troop of partisans; it was an entire army. There was therefore nothing for them to do but to follow the prudent advice of Monsieur d'Arminges and beat a retreat. They quickly went downstairs. Monsieur d'Arminges was already mounted. Olivain had ready the horses of the young men, and the lackeys of the Count de Guiche guarded carefully between them the Spanish prisoner, mounted on a pony which had been bought for his use. As a further precaution they had bound his hands.

The little company started off at a trot on the road to Cambrin, where they expected to find the prince. But he was no longer there, having withdrawn on the previous evening to La Bassée, misled by false intelligence of the enemy's movements. Deceived by this intelligence he had concentrated his forces between Vieille-Chapelle and La Venthie; and after a reconnoissance along the entire line, in company with Marshal de Grammont, he had returned and seated himself before a table, with his officers around him. He questioned them as to the news they had each been charged to obtain, but nothing positive had been learned. The

him not until he is dead; the lives of five men are not safe, in my opinion, as long as he is on the earth.'

And without adding another word, Grimaud, profiting by the astonishment and terror into which he had thrown his auditors, rushed from the room. Two minutes later the thunder of a horse's hoofs was heard upon the road; it was Grimaud, on his way to Paris. When once in the saddle Grimaud reflected on two things; first, that at the pace he was going his horse would not carry him ten miles, and secondly, that he had no money. But Grimaud's ingenuity was more prolific than his speech, and therefore at the first halt he sold his steed and with the money obtained from the purchase took post horses.

The peasant started off, running before the prince's horse

In about ten minutes they reached the ruins of an old château; those ruins crowned the summit of a hill which overlooked the surrounding country. At a distance of hardly a quarter of a league they looked down on Lens, at bay, and before Lens the enemy's entire army.

With a single glance the prince took in the extent of country that lay before him, from Lens as far as Vimy. In a moment the plan of the battle which on the following day was to save France the second time from invasion was unrolled in his mind. He took a pencil, tore a page from his tablets and wrote:

> My Dear Marshal,
>
> In an hour Lens will be in the enemy's possession. Come and rejoin me; bring with you the whole army. I shall be at Vendin to place it in position. To-morrow we shall retake Lens and beat the enemy.

Then, turning toward Raoul: 'Go, monsieur,' he said; 'ride fast and give this letter to Monsieur de Grammont.'

Raoul bowed, took the letter, went hastily down the mountain, leaped on his horse and set out at a gallop. A quarter of an hour later he was with the marshal.

A portion of the troops had already arrived and the remainder was expected from moment to moment. Marshal de Grammont put himself at the head of all the available cavalry and infantry and took the road to Vendin, leaving the Duc de Châtillon to await and bring on the rest. All the artillery was ready to move, and started off at a moment's notice.

It was seven o'clock in the evening when the marshal arrived at the appointed place. The prince awaited him there. As he had foreseen, Lens had fallen into the hands of the enemy immediately after Raoul's departure. The event was announced by the cessation of the firing.

As the shadows of night deepened the troops summoned by the prince arrived in successive detachments. Orders were given that no drum should be beaten, no trumpet sounded.

At nine o'clock the night had fully come. Still a last ray of twilight lighted the plain. The army marched silently, the prince at the head of the

'On the contrary, Olivain is to stay and I am to go. I have come for nothing else but to tell you so.'

'But what is the meaning of this change?'

'I cannot tell you.'

'Explain yourself.'

'I cannot explain myself.'

'Come, tell me, what is the joke?'

'Monsieur le vicomte knows that I never joke.'

'Yes, but I know also that Monsieur le Comte de la Fère arranged that you were to remain with me and that Olivain should return to Paris. I shall follow the count's directions.'

'Not under present circumstances, monsieur.'

'Perhaps you mean to disobey me?'

'Yes, monsieur, I must.'

'You persist, then?'

'Yes, I am going; may you be happy, monsieur,' and Grimaud saluted and turned toward the door to go out.

Raoul, angry and at the same time uneasy, ran after him and seized him by the arm. 'Grimaud!' he cried; 'remain; I wish it.'

'Then,' replied Grimaud, 'you wish me to allow monsieur le comte to be killed.' He saluted and made a movement to depart.

'Grimaud, my friend,' said the viscount, 'will you leave me thus, in such anxiety? Speak, speak, in Heaven's name!' And Raoul fell back trembling upon his chair.

'I can tell you but one thing, sir, for the secret you wish to know is not my own. You met a monk, did you not?'

'Yes.'

The young men looked at each other with an expression of fear.

'You conducted him to the wounded man and you had time to observe him, and perhaps you would know him again were you to meet him.'

'Yes, yes!' cried both young men.

'Very well; if ever you meet him again, wherever it may be, whether on the high road or in the street or in a church, anywhere that he or you may be, put your foot on his neck and crush him without pity, without mercy, as you would crush a viper or a scorpion! destroy him utterly and quit

again mounted his horse. Grimaud's first intention had been to return to Paris, but he remembered the anxiety which his prolonged absence might occasion Raoul, and reflecting that there were now only two miles between the vicomte and himself and a quarter of an hour's riding would unite them, and that the going, returning and explanation would not occupy an hour, he put spurs to his horse and a few minutes after had reached the only inn of Mazingarbe.

Raoul was seated at table with the Count de Guiche and his tutor, when all at once the door opened and Grimaud presented himself, travel-stained, dirty, and sprinkled with the blood of the unhappy executioner.

'Grimaud, my good Grimaud!' exclaimed Raoul 'here you are at last! Excuse me, sirs, this is not a servant, but a friend. How did you leave the count?' continued he. 'Does he regret me a little? Have you seen him since I left him? Answer, for I have many things to tell you, too; indeed, the last three days some odd adventures have happened—but what is the matter? how pale you are! and blood, too! What is this?'

'It is the blood of the unfortunate man whom you left at the inn and who died in my arms.'

'In your arms?—that man! but know you who he was?'

'He used to be the headsman of Bethune.'

'You knew him? and he is dead?'

'Yes.'

'Well, sir,' said D'Arminges, 'it is the common lot; even an executioner is not exempted. I had a bad opinion of him the moment I saw his wound, and since he asked for a monk you know that it was his opinion, too, that death would follow.'

At the mention of the monk, Grimaud became pale.

'Come, come,' continued D'Arminges, 'to dinner;' for like most men of his age and generation he did not allow sentiment or sensibility to interfere with a repast.

'You are right, sir,' said Raoul. 'Come, Grimaud, order dinner for yourself and when you have rested a little we can talk.'

'No, sir, no,' said Grimaud. 'I cannot stop a moment; I must start for Paris again immediately.'

'What? You start for Paris? You are mistaken; it is Olivain who leaves me; you are to remain.'

column. Presently the army came in sight of Lens; two or three houses were in flames and a dull noise was heard which indicated what suffering was endured by a town taken by assault.

The prince assigned to every one his post. Marshal de Grammont was to hold the extreme left, resting on Mericourt. The Duc de Châtillon commanded the centre. Finally, the prince led the right wing, resting on Aunay. The order of battle on the morrow was to be that of the positions taken in the evening. Each one, on awaking, would find himself on the field of battle.

The movement was executed in silence and with precision. At ten o'clock every one was in his appointed position; at half-past ten the prince visited the posts and gave his final orders for the following day.

Three things were especially urged upon the officers, who were to see that the soldiers observed them scrupulously: the first, that the different corps should so march that cavalry and infantry should be on the same line and that each body should protect its gaps; the second, to go to the charge no faster than a walk; the third, to let the enemy fire first.

The prince assigned the Count de Guiche to his father and kept Bragelonne near his own person; but the two young men sought the privilege of passing the night together and it was accorded them. A tent was erected for them near that of the marshal.

Although the day had been fatiguing, neither of them was inclined to sleep. And besides, even for old soldiers the evening before a battle is a serious time; it was so with greater reason to two young men who were about to witness for the first time that terrible spectacle. On the evening before a battle one thinks of a thousand things forgotten till then; those who are indifferent to one another become friends and those who are friends become brothers. It need not be said that if in the depths of the heart there is a sentiment more tender, it reaches then, quite naturally, the highest exaltation of which it is capable. Some sentiment of this kind must have been cherished by each one of these two friends, for each of them almost immediately sat down by himself at an end of the tent and began to write.

The letters were long—the four pages were covered with closely written words. The writers sometimes looked up at each other and smiled; they understood without speaking, their organizations were so delicate and

sympathetic. The letters being finished, each put his own into two envelopes, so that no one, without tearing the first envelope, could discover to whom the second was addressed; then they drew near to each other and smilingly exchanged their letters.

'In case any evil should happen to me,' said Bragelonne.

'In case I should be killed,' said De Guiche.

They then embraced each other like two brothers, and each wrapping himself in his cloak they soon passed into that kindly sleep of youth which is the prerogative of birds, flowers and infants.

'Haste! haste to him and warn him,' cried the wounded man, 'if he still lives; warn his friends, too. My death, believe me, will not be the end of this atrocious misadventure.'

'Where was the monk going?' asked Grimaud.

'Toward Paris.'

'Who stopped him?'

'Two young gentlemen, who were on their way to join the army and the name of one of whom I heard his companion mention—the Viscount de Bragelonne.'

'And it was this young man who brought the monk to you? Then it was the will of God that it should be so and this it is which makes it all so awful,' continued Grimaud. 'And yet that woman deserved her fate; do you not think so?'

'On one's death-bed the crimes of others appear very small in comparison with one's own,' said the executioner; and falling back exhausted he closed his eyes.

Grimaud was reluctant to leave the man alone and yet he perceived the necessity of starting at once to bear these tidings to the Comte de la Fère. Whilst he thus hesitated the host re-entered the room, followed not only by a surgeon, but by many other persons, whom curiosity had attracted to the spot. The surgeon approached the dying man, who seemed to have fainted.

'We must first extract the steel from the side,' said he, shaking his head in a significant manner.

The prophecy which the wounded man had just uttered recurred to Grimaud, who turned away his head. The weapon, as we have already stated, was plunged into the body to the hilt, and as the surgeon, taking it by the end, drew it forth, the wounded man opened his eyes and fixed them on him in a manner truly frightful. When at last the blade had been entirely withdrawn, a red froth issued from the mouth of the wounded man and a stream of blood spouted afresh from the wound when he at length drew breath; then, fixing his eyes upon Grimaud with a singular expression, the dying man uttered the last death-rattle and expired.

Then Grimaud, lifting the dagger from the pool of blood which was gliding along the room, to the horror of all present, made a sign to the host to follow him, paid him with a generosity worthy of his master and

'No, he was no longer here; he appears to have fled by the window. Was he the man that stabbed you?'

'Yes,' said the executioner.

Grimaud moved as if to leave the room.

'What are you going to do?' asked the wounded man.

'He must be apprehended.'

'Do not attempt it; he has revenged himself and has done well. Now I may hope that God will forgive me, since my crime is expiated.'

'Explain yourself.' said Grimaud.

'The woman whom you and your masters commanded me to kill— '

'Milady?'

'Yes, Milady; it is true you called her thus.'

'What has the monk to do with this Milady?'

'She was his mother.'

Grimaud trembled and stared at the dying man in a dull and leaden manner.

'His mother!' he repeated.

'Yes, his mother.'

'But does he know this secret, then?'

'I mistook him for a monk and revealed it to him in confession.'

'Unhappy man!' cried Grimaud, whose face was covered with sweat at the bare idea of the evil results such a revelation might cause; 'unhappy man, you named no one, I hope?'

'I pronounced no name, for I knew none, except his mother's, as a young girl, and it was by this name that he recognised her, but he knows that his uncle was among her judges.'

Thus speaking, he fell back exhausted. Grimaud, wishing to relieve him, advanced his hand toward the hilt of the dagger.

'Touch me not!' said the executioner; 'if this dagger is withdrawn I shall die.'

Grimaud remained with his hand extended; then, striking his forehead, he exclaimed:

'Oh! if this man should ever discover the names of the others, my master is lost.'

Chapter XXXV

A Dinner in the Old Style

THE second interview between the former musketeers was not so formal and threatening as the first. Athos, with his superior understanding, wisely deemed that the supper table would be the most complete and satisfactory point of reunion, and at the moment when his friends, in deference to his deportment and sobriety, dared scarcely speak of some of their former good dinners, he was the first to propose that they should all assemble around some well spread table and abandon themselves unreservedly to their own natural character and manners—a freedom which had formerly contributed so much to that good understanding between them which gave them the name of the inseparables. For different reasons this was an agreeable proposition to them all, and it was therefore agreed that each should leave a very exact address and that upon the request of any of the associates a meeting should be convoked at a famous eating house in the Rue de la Monnaie, of the sign of the Hermitage. The first rendezvous was fixed for the following Wednesday, at eight o'clock in the evening precisely.

On that day, in fact, the four friends arrived punctually at the hour, each from his own abode or occupation. Porthos had been trying a new horse; D'Artagnan was on guard at the Louvre; Aramis had been to visit one of his penitents in the neighbourhood; and Athos, whose domicile was established in the Rue Guénégaud, found himself close at hand. They were, therefore, somewhat surprised to meet altogether at the door of the Hermitage, Athos starting out from the Pont Neuf, Porthos by the Rue de la Roule, D'Artagnan by the Rue des Fosse Saint Germain l'Auxerrois, and Aramis by the Rue de Bethisy.

The first words exchanged between the four friends, on account of the ceremony which each of them mingled with their demonstration, were somewhat forced and even the repast began with a kind of stiffness. Athos perceived this embarrassment, and by way of supplying an effectual remedy, called for four bottles of champagne.

At this order, given in Athos's habitually calm manner, the face of the Gascon relaxed and Porthos's brow grew smooth. Aramis was astonished. He knew that Athos not only never drank, but more, that he had a kind of repugnance to wine. This astonishment was doubled when Aramis saw Athos fill a bumper and toss it off with all his former enthusiasm. His companions followed his example. In a very few minutes the four bottles were empty and this excellent specific succeeded in dissipating even the slightest cloud that might have rested on their spirits. Now the four friends began to speak loud, scarcely waiting till one had finished before another began, and each assumed his favourite attitude on or at the table. Soon—strange fact—Aramis undid two buttons of his doublet, seeing which, Porthos unfastened his entirely.

Battles, long journeys, blows given and received, sufficed for the first themes of conversation, which turned upon the silent struggles sustained against him who was now called the great cardinal.

'Faith,' said Aramis, laughing, 'we have praised the dead enough, let us revile the living a little; I should like to say something evil of Mazarin; is it permissible?'

'Go on, go on,' replied D'Artagnan, laughing heartily; 'relate your story and I will applaud it if it is a good one.'

'A great prince,' said Aramis, 'with whom Mazarin sought an alliance, was invited by him to send him a list of the conditions on which he would do him the honour to negotiate with him. The prince, who had a great repugnance to treat with such an ill-bred fellow, made out a list, against the grain, and sent it. In this list there were three conditions which displeased Mazarin and he offered the prince ten thousand crowns to renounce them.'

'Ah, ha, ha!' laughed the three friends, 'not a bad bargain; and there was no fear of being taken at his word; what did the prince do then?'

Chapter XXXIII

Grimaud Speaks

GRIMAUD was left alone with the executioner, who in a few moments opened his eyes.

'Help, help,' he murmured; 'oh, God! have I not a single friend in the world who will aid me either to live or to die?'

'Take courage,' said Grimaud; 'they are gone to find assistance.'

'Who are you?' asked the wounded man, fixing his half opened eyes on Grimaud.

'An old acquaintance,' replied Grimaud.

'You?' and the wounded man sought to recall the features of the person now before him.

'Under what circumstances did we meet?' he asked again.

'One night, twenty years ago, my master fetched you from Bethune and conducted you to Armentières.'

'I know you well now,' said the executioner; 'you were one of the four grooms.'

'Just so.'

'Where do you come from now?'

'I was passing by and drew up at this inn to rest my horse. They told me the executioner of Bethune was here and wounded, when you uttered two piercing cries. At the first we ran to the door and at the second forced it open.'

'And the monk?' exclaimed the executioner, 'did you see the monk?'

'What monk?'

'The monk that was shut in with me.'